

AZTECS



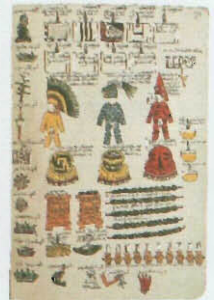
A GREAT IMPERIAL power, the Aztecs came to dominate the Valley of Mexico

in less than a hundred years. Egged on by bloodthirsty gods, they were a warlike people, outstanding for their military skill and well organized society. By the time the Spanish conquistador Hernán Cortés (1485–1547) arrived in 1519, the Aztecs and their allies were rulers of some 25 million people.



Rise of the Aztecs

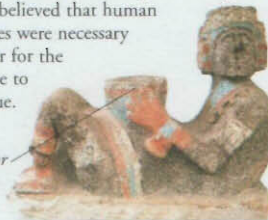
The Aztecs were one of many tribes who invaded the Valley of Mexico soon after the collapse of the Toltecs in the late 12th century. They dominated the valley after 1438.



Human sacrifice

When they won a war, the Aztecs killed many prisoners as offerings to their gods. Aztecs believed that human sacrifices were necessary in order for the universe to continue.

Dish for human heart



Subject peoples

The Aztecs ruled over a network of city states. Subject peoples made regular payments to their Aztec overlords, in the form of maize, cacao, or cotton. As long as this "tribute" was paid, the peoples of the Valley of Mexico were left to govern themselves and to keep their customs.

Aztec society

Commoners lived in small mud houses and grew crops on the marshes. They dressed and ate simply. The nobles were warriors, tribute collectors, and judges; they were rewarded for their services with land.



Customs

Aztec customs included an elaborate naming ceremony for newborn babies.



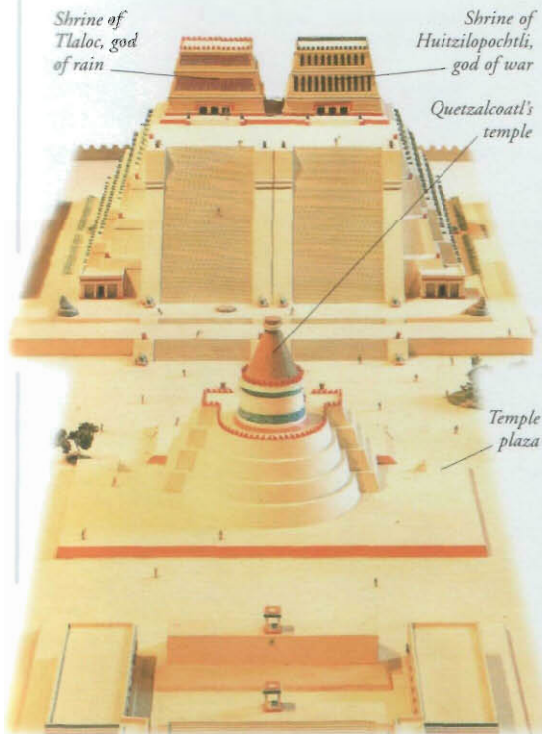
School teacher

Tenochtitlán

A city of canals and narrow streets, the Aztec capital was built on an island in Lake Texcoco. It was linked to the land by three narrow causeways. The city was home to 200,000 people – four or five times larger than any European city of the time. Most people lived in small houses in the narrow streets surrounding an area of temples – the Great Precinct.

Great Precinct

The centre of Tenochtitlán was dominated by the Great Precinct, surrounded by a wall decorated with huge serpent heads. Inside the enclosure were the temples of the leading gods. A skull rack displayed the heads of countless victims of human sacrifice.



Aztecs on the eve of conquest

By the early 16th century, the Aztec empire was showing signs of weakness. Shortly before the arrival of Cortés, priests and nobles were worried by a series of omens that seemed to forecast Aztec decline. These omens included the rumbling of the volcano Popocatepetl.



Quetzalcoatl

The Aztecs believed that the god Quetzalcoatl had been driven from his kingdom and would return to begin a golden age. When Cortés arrived, they thought he was the god. But the noise of Popocatepetl seemed to be an omen of defeat.

Popocatepetl

Quetzalcoatl, the feathered serpent



Montezuma II

The emperor Montezuma II (c.1466–1520) was unsure if Cortés was Quetzalcoatl, and did not repel the Spanish when they arrived. Cortés and his small army got as far as the capital, and Montezuma welcomed them there. But the Spanish seized the emperor and took him hostage. Montezuma died in prison, the last Aztec ruler.



Conquest of the Aztecs

In April 1519, Cortés founded Veracruz on the coast of the Gulf of Mexico, inside the Aztec empire. With his army of 600 men and 16 horses, he advanced towards Tenochtitlán, forging alliances with Aztec enemies. By August 1521, the Spanish had occupied Tenochtitlán, after laying siege with the help of many local soldiers.

Defeat by Tlaxcala

The growing thirst for human sacrifice led Aztecs to wage constant war on the neighbouring Tlaxcalans. Four years before the arrival of Cortés, the Tlaxcalans inflicted a heavy defeat on the Aztec armies, greatly weakening the empire.



FIND OUT MORE

CENTRAL AMERICA, HISTORY OF

MAYA

MESOAMERICANS

OLMECS